

The Library of Unlived Lives

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The Librarian of Unlived Lives

The door didn't look like a door. It looked like the memory of one — a rectangle of darker shadow against the library wall, hinges rusted into silence, handle cold as a winter morning. The traveler had been walking for what felt like years through corridors that folded back on themselves like origami, past shelves that breathed with the slow respiration of forgotten possibilities.

They stopped. The air tasted of dust and ink and something sharper — ozone, maybe, or the metallic tang of choices never made.

“Welcome,” said a voice from nowhere and everywhere. It didn’t echo. It simply was, like light in a room that had always been lit.

The traveler turned. Behind a desk carved from a single piece of dark wood sat a woman who might have been thirty or three hundred. Her fingers were stained with ink. Her eyes held the particular fatigue of someone who has read every ending before the story begins.

“Who are you?” the traveler asked.

“I am the keeper,” she said. “Of the lives you did not live. Of the paths you walked past. Of the doors you did not open.” She gestured at the shelves stretching into fog. “Each book here is a version of you. The you who stayed. The you who left. The you who loved the woman on the train platform. The you who boarded the ship. The you who said yes. The you who said no.”

The traveler’s throat tightened. “All of them?”

“All of them.” She pulled a volume from the shelf nearest her elbow. Its cover was blank. “Shall we begin?”

The first life opened not with fanfare but with the smell of rain on hot asphalt.

*You are twenty-seven. You are standing on a platform in Chicago, summer 2019. The train to Boston whistles. In your pocket: a ticket. In your hand: a phone screen glowing with a message you have read seventeen times. I’ll wait. Whatever you decide.**

You board the train.

The version of you who stays becomes a footnote in someone else’s story — a ghost in a Chicago apartment, growing quieter each year, learning to love the shape of your own absence.

The version of you who leaves — *this* version — finds Boston wrapped in October fog. You rent a room in a house with three other dreamers. You write code by day and poems by night. You meet a woman named Sarah in a bookstore on Beacon Street. She is reaching for the same collection of Rilke. Your fingers brush. The contact sends a current through you that feels like recognition.

Three years later, you marry in a ceremony so small it barely qualifies as ritual. Five years after that, a daughter. You name her Maya, after the illusion that binds the world. She has your mother’s hands and Sarah’s laugh.

You are happy. The word feels strange in your mouth, like foreign currency. But it fits. You are happy the way a cup fits a saucer — not perfect, but made for each other.

At forty-two, Sarah dies. A car. An intersection. A moment of distracted driving that unravels everything.

You don't write poems after. You don't code. You sit in the kitchen at three a.m. staring at her coffee mug, still on the counter, still holding the ghost of her lipstick stain.

Maya grows. She leaves. She returns with a man who is kind and a granddaughter who has Sarah's eyes.

You die at seventy-nine, holding that mug, finally understanding that happiness was not the years you had but the way you held them.

The book snapped shut. The sound was final. A coffin lid. A period.

The traveler's hands trembled.

"Was that — was that real?"

The keeper's expression didn't change. "As real as the life you're living now. As real as the one where you never entered this library. Reality isn't a single thread, traveler. It's a tapestry. You've simply been shown one panel."

"She died," the traveler whispered. "Sarah. She died."

"In that life. In this one, she may never have existed. Or you may never have met. Or you may have met and parted without marriage. Or married and divorced. Or —" The keeper spread ink-stained fingers. "The combinations are infinite. The grief is finite. That's the mercy."

"Mercy." The word tasted like ash. "I felt thirty years in three minutes. I *loved* her. I *lost* her. How is that mercy?"

"Because you also felt the loving. The holding. The coffee mug. The granddaughter's eyes." The keeper returned the book to its shelf, drew another. "Would you like to see the life where you stay in Chicago? Where you become the ghost in the apartment? Where you learn to love your own absence?"

The traveler stared at the blank cover of the new book. Their reflection in the dark surface looked older than they remembered. Or perhaps younger. Time moved differently here.

"Will it hurt?"

"All of them hurt," the keeper said gently. "But they hurt in different ways. And some of them — some of them also heal."

The traveler reached out. Their fingers brushed the cover.

Open.

In the margin of the first book, in ink that hadn't been there a moment before, a single line appeared in the traveler's own handwriting:

I did not know I could miss someone I never met.

The library breathed. Somewhere, a page turned itself.

The Architecture of Absence

The second book was heavier. Not in weight — in the way gravity increases near something dense and lightless. The cover was the same blank gray, but the traveler's fingers knew before they opened it: this one would not end with a granddaughter's eyes.

Open.

You are twenty-seven. You are standing on a platform in Chicago, summer 2019. The train to Boston whistles. In your pocket: a ticket. In your hand: a phone screen glowing with a message you have read seventeen times. *I'll wait. Whatever you decide.*

You do not board.

The train pulls away, taking the other you with it — the one who writes poems, who meets Sarah in a bookstore, who names a daughter Maya, who loses her at forty-two and spends thirty-seven years holding a coffee mug.

You stay.

The apartment on Wilson Avenue is small. Third floor. The radiator clanks in January like a dying man. The landlord, Mrs. Kowalski, brings you pierogi on Christmas and asks when you'll bring a nice girl home. You smile. You say soon. You never do.

You keep the job at the insurance firm. You are good at it — the quiet arithmetic of risk, the clean logic of actuarial tables. Numbers don't leave. Numbers don't die in car accidents at intersections. Numbers don't look at you with Sarah's eyes and ask why you stopped writing poems.

Your colleagues like you. They invite you to happy hours. You go, sometimes. You nurse a beer and listen to them talk about mortgages and children and the Cubs. You contribute observations about probability. They laugh. You are the smart one. The quiet one. The one who will die alone, they think, but kindly.

At thirty-three, your mother calls. Your father has fallen. A stroke. Not the kind you recover from.

You move back to the house on Maple Street. The one with the porch swing your father built. The one where you grew up learning that love looks like showing up, day after day, for the small things.

You care for him. You learn the rhythm of his body — the pills at six and noon and six, the sponge baths, the way his hand finds yours when the pain spikes. You read to him. Not poems. The newspaper. The sports section. The obituaries, which he insists on checking for names he knows.

He dies on a Tuesday in November. The light in the room doesn't change. The radiator doesn't clank differently. You sit beside him for three hours after the breath stops, because you don't know what else to do.

Mrs. Kowalski brings pierogi to the funeral. She hugs you and says, "Such a good son." You want to tell her you weren't good. You were just there. That there is no goodness in doing what you have to do.

You return to Wilson Avenue. The apartment smells like dust and old pierogi. You throw out the pierogi. You keep the dust.

At forty-two — the age the other you lost Sarah — you receive a wedding invitation. Sarah. She married a man named David. They live in Boston. She sends a photo. Two children. A boy and a girl. The girl has her laugh.

You stare at the photo for a long time. You do not cry. You have forgotten how.

You write a check for two hundred dollars. You do not attend.

At fifty-five, you retire. The insurance firm gives you a watch. You sell it on eBay for forty-seven dollars.

You travel. Not to Boston. Not to anywhere with meaning. You go to Iceland and stand on a black sand beach and watch the Atlantic eat the shore. You go to Kyoto and sit in a temple garden and watch moss grow on stones. You go to the Atacama and look at stars so thick they cast shadows.

You are searching for something. You don't know what. The feeling you had at twenty-seven on that platform, perhaps. The certainty that a choice existed.

At seventy-two, you fall in your kitchen. A hip. The surgery goes well. The rehab does not.

Maya — no. Not Maya. There is no Maya. There is only a niece, your sister's daughter, who visits on Sundays and brings grocery bags and calls you Uncle and means it.

She reads to you now. The newspaper. The sports section. The obituaries.

You die at seventy-nine in a hospital room that smells like antiseptic and regret. Not the sharp regret of loss — the dull regret of never having risked it.

Your last thought is not of Sarah. It is of the train. The whistle. The ticket burning in your pocket.

I'll wait. Whatever you decide.

You never told her you decided.

The book snapped shut.

The traveler stood very still in the library's dim light. Their hands were clenched around the cover. Their breathing had gone shallow.

“That one,” they said, voice cracking. “That one was worse.”

The keeper didn’t look up from the volume she was reshelving. “Worse than watching the woman you love die in a car accident? Worse than thirty-seven years of grief?”

“Different.” The traveler swallowed. “The other one — the other me — he *loved*. He *had*. He lost, yes, but he *had*. This one...” They gestured helplessly at the book. “This one just... waited. For seventy-two years. Waited for a life to happen to him.”

“Did it not happen?”

“What?”

“His life. Did it not happen?” The keeper’s voice was mild. “He cared for his father. He witnessed his mother’s aging. He stood on black sand in Iceland. He saw stars in the Atacama that most humans never see. He was an uncle. A son. A colleague who made people laugh with probability jokes. He *was*.”

“He was alone.”

“Was he?” The keeper slid the book back onto the shelf. “Or was he the version of you who chose witness over participation? Who chose depth over breadth? Who loved not a person but the shape of a life lived quietly?”

“He didn’t *choose*.” The traveler’s voice rose. “He *defaulted*. He stood on the platform and let the train leave because he was afraid. That’s not a choice. That’s cowardice wearing patience’s clothes.”

The keeper stopped. Her ink-stained fingers rested on a third volume.

“Is it?”

The question hung in the air between them. Somewhere in the library, a shelf exhaled.

“Tell me, traveler,” the keeper said softly. “In the life you’re living now — the one outside this library — how many trains have you let leave because you were afraid?”

The traveler’s mouth opened. Closed.

The keeper pulled the third book down. Its cover was blank. But in the traveler’s reflection, the title seemed to shimmer into existence:

The Life Where You Asked the Question

“Shall we?” she asked.

The traveler looked at their reflection. At the lines around eyes that had seen two lifetimes in ten minutes. At the gray threading through hair that had been dark when they entered.

“Yes,” they said. “Show me.”

In the margin of the second book, in ink that matched the first, a new line appeared:

I did not know that not-choosing was also a choice. That the ghost in the apartment was me all along..

The Cartographer of Things Unseen

The third book was not on the shelf where the keeper had placed it.

The traveler turned. The book sat on the floor at their feet, open to a blank page that somehow reflected not light but *sound* — a low hum, like a cello held too long, like the vibration of a bridge before it falls.

“Your hands,” the keeper said quietly, “are shaking.”

The traveler looked down. They were.

“Before you open this one,” the keeper said, “know that this life is not on the same map. The Chicago platform, the train to Boston — those are small branches on a tree we both understand. This one...” She hesitated. A first. “This one is a different tree.”

“I don’t understand.”

“You will.”

Open.

You are born in a room with no corners.

This is the first thing you know: a room that curves like the inside of an egg. The walls hum. The light comes not from any source you can name but from the air itself, the molecules glowing with the effort of existence.

Your mother is a woman who speaks to trees. Your father is a man who has been walking for forty years toward a mountain he will never reach.

You are born knowing three languages: the one of the body, the one of the earth, and the one of the spaces between stars.

You grow up learning that pain is not an enemy. That grief is a form of attention. That love is not something you feel but something you *do* — a verb with no past tense.

At twelve, you walk into the desert with nothing but a jar of water and a question you cannot pronounce. You stay for three days. When you return, your mother sees that you have become someone else. She does not say this. She does not need to. You are both fluent in the language of the spaces between.

At seventeen, you fall in love with a boy who carries a violin case everywhere. He does not know how to play. He carries it because he believes in the possibility of music. You

love him for this. For the way he treats potential as a physical thing, something you can hold.

You stay together for three years. Then he finds his violin teacher. Then he learns. Then he leaves.

You do not blame him. You understand that the thing you loved in him — the belief in possibility — was always going to consume him. That is what possibilities do.

At twenty-four, you begin to draw maps. Not maps of places. Maps of *relationships* — the invisible threads between people, between moments, between a hand reaching and a hand received. The maps are beautiful and useless. You know this. You make them anyway.

At thirty, you meet a woman in a library. Not this library. A smaller one. She is reading a book about moss. You tell her that moss is the oldest form of patience. She laughs. She says moss doesn't need patience — it has all the time there is.

You marry her. You have children. The children are strange and wonderful and they speak the language of the spaces between even before you teach them.

At fifty — no, at forty-seven, at sixty-two, at thirty-three — time begins to fold. This is the first life where you cannot hold a linear story. Events pile on top of each other like sediment. You are twenty-five and seventy at the same moment. You are holding your father's hand as he dies. You are holding your daughter's hand as she is born. Both hands are the same temperature.

You learn that time is not a river but an ocean. That every moment exists simultaneously. That the past does not end. That the future has already happened.

You are happy. Not in the way the first life was happy — the cup fitting the saucer. Not in the way the second life was not-happy — the dull ache of absence chosen. This happiness is different. It is the happiness of knowing too much. Of seeing the threads that connect everything and accepting that you cannot untangle them.

You die at ninety-three, surrounded by children and grandchildren and great-grandchildren. Your last word is a sound that has no translation. It means, approximately: *I have seen the shape of the ocean and I am not afraid of drowning.*

The book did not have to shut. The traveler closed it themselves.

"I don't understand what I just saw," they said. "Was that — was that me? Or was that someone else entirely?"

The keeper was watching them with an expression the traveler could not read. "What is a self but the sum of your choices? If you had been born into a different world, with different rules, different parents, different languages — would you still be *you*?"

"I don't know."

“Neither do I.” The keeper’s voice was softer than it had been. “That’s the terror and the gift of this library. Some of these books will show you yourself. Some will show you a stranger wearing your face. And some —” She gestured at the third volume. “Some will show you a door you did not know existed, in a wall you had never seen.”

The traveler looked at the book in their hands. The blank cover now bore a title, shimmering into visibility:

The Life Where You Saw the Shape of Everything

“And the fourth?” the traveler asked.

The keeper smiled. It was not a comforting smile.

“The fourth is the one you have been avoiding since you walked through the door.”

“I haven’t been avoiding anything.”

“Haven’t you?”

The traveler opened their mouth to argue. Stopped. The keeper’s eyes held no judgment. Only the same patient fatigue the traveler had noticed at the beginning — the fatigue of someone who has seen this conversation a thousand times before.

“Show me,” the traveler said.

The keeper shook her head. “Not yet. First, you must see the one where you never came here at all.”

“What?”

But the keeper was already walking deeper into the stacks. The traveler followed, the third book still warm in their hands.

In the margin of the third book, in the traveler’s own hand, a line that seemed to write itself in reverse:

I did not know that time was an ocean. That the drowning is the same as the swimming..

The Life You Were Living

The keeper stopped in front of a section of the library that looked different from the others. The shelves here were lower. The books were thinner. The light fell differently — dimmer, more yellow, as if filtered through memory.

“These are not lives you could have lived,” she said. “These are the lives you *are* living. The life you walked out of when you found this library. It’s still happening. Out there, in the world with doors and windows and other people.”

The traveler felt a coldness settle in their chest. “I don’t want to see it.”

“I know.”

“I don’t need to see it. I know what’s there. That’s why I came here.”

“I know.” The keeper pulled a book from the shelf. It was not blank. Its cover bore a title the traveler recognized with a physical ache:

The Life Where You Stayed

“This is not an alternate life,” the keeper said. “This is the one you left behind. The one that was already yours.”

“I know what’s in it.”

“Do you?”

You are thirty-one. You live in a city you chose at twenty-two because you liked the train station. You work a job that pays the bills and leaves you too tired at the end of the day to ask whether it means anything.

You have a partner. Their name is Sam. You have been together for six years. You love them in the way you love an old coat — not with passion, but with the quiet certainty that it has kept you warm through many winters.

Sam wants children. You have been saying “soon” for three years. Soon, when the work settles. Soon, when we have more space. Soon, when I feel ready.

You do not know what “ready” means. You suspect you will never know.

Your mother calls every Sunday. You let it go to voicemail half the time. You call back on Tuesday. You tell her you’ve been busy. You have not been busy. You have been sitting on the couch, scrolling, feeling the hours dissolve like sugar in rain.

Your father — you don’t talk to your father. Not in the way that matters. You exchange texts on birthdays. He sends articles about interest rates. You send photos of the cat. Neither of you mentions the silence.

You stopped writing poetry at twenty-four. Not because you lost the ability. Because you started to wonder who would read it, and the answer was no one, and that seemed to make the act of writing pointless. You did not understand then — you do not understand now — that the point was never in the reading.

At twenty-six, a friend killed himself. You went to the funeral. You stood in the rain and watched them lower his body into the ground and you felt nothing. Not grief. Not shock. Nothing. The absence of feeling was so vast it had its own gravity. You have been falling into it ever since.

At twenty-eight, you started going to a therapist. You sat in her office and talked about your childhood. You learned words like “attachment” and “avoidance” and “emotional regulation.” The words helped. They built a scaffold over the emptiness. But the emptiness did not go away.

The emptiness is still there. You have learned to live with it. You have learned to decorate it with routines. Morning coffee. Evening walk. Friday night takeout. Sunday cleaning. The routines are beautiful. They are architecture. They are the walls you have built around the hole you fell into at twenty-six and never climbed out of.

You met a stranger in a bar six months ago. They told you about a library. A library of lives. A library where you could step into the person you might have been.

You laughed. You bought them a drink. You went home and googled “library of unlived lives” and found nothing.

But you could not stop thinking about it.

Three months ago, you started looking for the door. You did not tell Sam. You did not tell anyone. You walked through the city with your eyes half-closed, searching for the corner of a building that didn’t quite fit, the alley that shouldn’t be there, the door that was a memory of a door.

You found it yesterday.

You walked through it.

You left Sam sleeping.

The book did not have to be read. The traveler had lived every word.

“Is Sam okay?” they asked. Their voice was barely a whisper.

“Time moves differently here,” the keeper said. “When you return — if you return — it will have been an hour. Or a day. Or a year. The library does not keep track.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“No.” The keeper held their gaze. “It’s not.”

The traveler looked at the book in their hands. Their own life. Thin. Sparse. A skeleton of days.

“Is this,” they said slowly, “the life I was supposed to live? The *real* one?”

“There is no such thing.”

“But all those other lives —”

“Were as real as this one. The Boston life. The Chicago life. The life in the room with no corners. They are all real. They are all *you*. The difference is that this one —” She touched the cover. “This one you are actually living. These are days you have actually had. This is coffee you have actually tasted. This is Sam’s hand you have actually held.”

The traveler looked at the book. Looked at the shelf. Looked at the thousands of other volumes stretching into the dim light.

“How many more?” they asked.

“Three,” the keeper said. “After this, there are three more. But you do not have to open them. You can leave. You can go back through the door. You can wake up next to Sam and say, ‘I had the strangest dream.’ ”

“And if I stay?”

“Then you will see the life where you said yes to children. The life where you ran away at nineteen and never came back. The life where you called your father. The life where you didn’t.”

The traveler closed their eyes.

The library waited.

“What do you want?” the keeper asked.

The question was so simple. So impossible.

“I want,” the traveler said, “to stop being afraid of my own life.”

The keeper nodded. She did not say anything. She did not need to.

The traveler opened their eyes and reached for the next book.

In the margin of the fourth book, in the traveler’s own hand, a line appeared in ink that looked like tears:

I did not know that the life I was running from was the one I should have been running toward..

The Life Where You Said Yes

“The children one,” the traveler said before the keeper could offer.

“You’re sure?”

“I saw the life where I stayed. Now I want to see the life where I didn’t.” They reached for the shelf themselves, fingers brushing a spine that seemed to warm at their touch.

“The one where I said yes.”

The keeper stepped aside.

You are thirty-one. You have been saying “soon” for three years. Sam’s patience has begun to show its edges — not in words, but in the way they look at other people’s children in the grocery store. In the way their hand rests on their own stomach while watching TV. In the silence that stretches between you at night, neither of you asleep.

You say yes on a Tuesday.

The words come out wrong — not romantic, not decisive, just tired. “Okay. Let’s try.”

Sam’s face breaks into something you have not seen before. A smile that starts in their chest and spreads outward like sunrise. You realize, in that moment, that you have been the keeper of their fear for three years. That you could have lifted it with two words at any time.

And you chose not to.

The thought sits in you like a stone.

The pregnancy is not easy. The first trimester, Sam is sick every morning. The second, they are tired every afternoon. The third, they cannot sleep at all. You learn to make ginger tea. You learn to rub feet without being asked. You learn that love is not a feeling but a series of small, unglamorous actions performed until they become automatic.

The baby is born at 3:47 AM on a Tuesday. The same day of the week you said yes. You hold her before they clean her, before they weigh her, before anything. She is the ugliest thing you have ever seen — wrinkled, purple, screaming — and you love her with a ferocity that terrifies you.

You name her Elena. After no one. Because she is the first of her kind.

The first year is a war of attrition.

You do not sleep. You do not shower. You forget to eat. You learn that a human being can function on two hours of sleep for months, and that the cost of this is a slow unraveling of the self. You forget who you were before Elena. You do not miss that person.

Sam is better at this than you. They have an instinct for the rhythms of care that you lack. You watch them with the baby and feel like an imposter — a child playing at adulthood, waiting to be found out.

But you stay. You show up. You learn.

At eighteen months, Elena says her first word. It is not “Mama” or “Dada.” It is “again.” Sam cries. You laugh. The laugh surprises you. It has been so long since you made that sound.

At four, Elena asks you where the moon goes during the day.

“It doesn’t go anywhere,” you say. “It’s still there. The sun just makes it harder to see.”

She considers this. “So it’s hiding?”

“Not hiding. Just... outshone.”

She nods, satisfied. She has your thoughtfulness and Sam's warmth. You look at her and see the best parts of both of you, amplified. You understand, for the first time, what people mean when they say children make you want to be better.

At six, she asks why you and Sam never got married.

"Some people don't need papers," you say.

"Do you love each other?"

"Yes."

"Then why don't you want the papers?"

You do not have an answer.

At eight, she asks if she can call you "Dad." You have not thought about this. You and Sam have always been Sam and Parent. The word "Dad" belongs to the man who sends you articles about interest rates. But Elena is looking at you with the complete faith of a child who has never been disappointed by you yet.

"Yes," you say. "You can call me Dad."

At ten, Sam's mother dies. Sam is gone for a month, flying to another state to handle the funeral, the estate, the grief. You stay with Elena. You cook. You clean. You help with homework. You lie awake at night wondering if you are doing enough.

When Sam returns, they are thinner. Older. They sit on the couch and cry for three hours while you hold them.

"I don't want to be that alone," they say.

"You're not."

"I mean when my mom died. The way she was alone at the end."

"Sam. You have us."

Sam looks at you. At the pictures of Elena on the wall. At the kitchen where the dishes are done and the laundry is folded.

"I know," they say. "I know."

At twelve, Elena is bullied at school. She comes home with her face red and her eyes swollen. She tells you the other kids said her family is weird because you and Sam aren't married.

You sit with her for three hours. You tell her about the library. Not the real library — the library of lives you never found. You tell her about the life where you didn't say yes. Where you stayed on the platform in Chicago. Where you let the train leave without you.

She asks if that you is happy.
“No,” you say. “I don’t think he is.”
“Am I happy?” she asks.
“You tell me.”
She thinks about it. “I think so.”
“That’s all that matters.”

At fifteen, she asks about the other parent. The one who came before Sam. You tell her there is no other parent. That she came from you and Sam, in the way that matters — through choice, through care, through showing up every day for fifteen years.
She looks at you with the skepticism of adolescence.
“I’m going to ask Sam,” she says.
“Sam will tell you the same thing.”
She goes. Sam does.

At eighteen, she leaves for college. The house is silent in a way it has never been. You walk into her room and find a drawing she made when she was six: three stick figures under a sun. You are all holding hands. The drawing says, in wobbly letters: “MY FAMILY.”
You sit on her bed and cry.
Sam finds you there. They do not say anything. They just sit next to you and hold your hand.

At twenty-one, Elena calls to say she is in love. A woman named Priya. She is an architect. She builds things from the ground up, which is, Elena says, “the best metaphor you could ask for.”
You are happy for her. The happiness surprises you — not the fact of it, but the purity. No jealousy. No longing. No shadow of the life you might have lived instead.
This life. This is the life you chose.

The book ended not with death but with an open door. The traveler closed it gently, as if it might break.
“She’s not real,” the traveler said. “Elena. She’s not real. I never said yes.”
“Is that what you think?” the keeper asked.

“Sam and I — we never had children. I never said yes. That life never happened.”

“Did it not?” The keeper tilted her head. “Open the book again.”

The traveler did.

The final page now read:

In the life where you said yes, Elena learned to whistle at three, cried at every Disney movie until she was twelve, dyed her hair purple at sixteen (it looked terrible), and became an engineer because she wanted to build things that lasted. She has Sam’s laugh and your handwriting. She is real in the only way that matters: you loved her enough to imagine her.

In the margin of the fifth book, a line appeared:

I did not know that a life imagined is still a life lived. That saying yes to what you fear is the same as saying yes to what you love..

The Life Where You Called

The traveler’s hand hovered over the shelf. They did not reach for a book. They stood, frozen, in the dim light of the library, and the keeper waited.

“The father one,” the traveler said finally. “The life where I called.”

“Are you ready?”

“No.”

The keeper nodded. She pulled the book herself. It was the thinnest one yet — a few dozen pages, barely a pamphlet. Its cover was not blank. It was the color of old telephone wires, the color of a receiver left off the hook too long.

You are thirty-one. Your father is sixty-three. He has heart problems. He has not told you this because you have not asked.

The last real conversation you had with him was at twenty-two. You told him you were moving. He told you about interest rates. You told him you felt like you were disappearing. He told you about the housing market. You have not tried again since.

This is a story about a phone call.

You pick up the phone on a Sunday afternoon. Sam is out with friends. Elena is at a birthday party. The house is quiet. You have been thinking about the library — the one you never found — and it occurs to you, sharply, that the library was never a place. It was an excuse. A door you invented so you wouldn’t have to open the real one.

You dial.

He answers on the third ring. His voice sounds the same. Deeper. Slower. Your mother's voice in the background, asking who it is.

"Dad."

A pause.

"Is everything okay?"

The question is reflex. For thirty-one years, the only time you call is when something is wrong. You have trained him to expect disaster.

"Everything's fine," you say. And then, because you have spent your entire life in conversations that circled around the thing that needed to be said: "I just wanted to talk."

Another pause. Longer.

"About what?"

"I don't know."

The silence stretches. It is not uncomfortable. It is the silence of two people who have forgotten how to speak to each other, learning the shape of it again.

"Sam got a promotion," you say. "Elena is doing a science project. Volcanoes." You have no idea why you are telling him this. He sends articles about interest rates. He does not care about volcanoes.

"I built a volcano for your sister once," he says. "Baking soda and vinegar. She cried when it erupted."

"She was three."

"She was terrified of messes."

You laugh. The surprise of it. Your father made your sister cry with a baking soda volcano more than thirty years ago, and you are laughing.

"She's a doctor now," he says.

"I know."

"And you. You're —" He stops. "You're happy?"

The question is so simple. So impossible. You think about Sam. About Elena. About the job that pays the bills. About the poetry you stopped writing. About the friend who died. About the emptiness you have decorated with routines.

"Yes," you say. "I think I am."

"That's good." His voice cracks, barely. "That's all I ever wanted."

You do not know what to say to this. It is too much. It is too little. It is thirty-one years of silence compressed into seven words.

“Dad.”

“Yeah?”

“Your heart. Are you okay?”

A long pause. So long you think the line has gone dead.

“How did you know?”

“Mom mentioned it. Last year.”

“Your mother talks too much.”

“She worries.”

“She’s always worried. That’s her job.”

“Dad.”

“Yeah?”

“I worry too.”

The pause after this is different. Softer. The pause of a man who has spent sixty-three years learning that he is not supposed to show weakness, and is only now, in this conversation, discovering that he has been wrong.

“I had a scare,” he says. “Last winter. They put in a stent. I’m fine now.”

“You should have told me.”

“I didn’t want to worry you.”

“You just said worrying is Mom’s job.”

“I lied.”

You laugh again. He laughs too. Two people laughing on the phone about heart stents. This is what family sounds like, you realize. Laughter over the things that terrify you.

“I love you,” you say.

The words come out before you can stop them. You have not said this to him since you were a child. You are not sure you have ever said it as an adult.

“I know,” he says.

It is not the answer you wanted. But it is the answer you needed.

“I know,” he says again, and this time the words are fuller. “I know you do.”

Nothing changes overnight. He does not become a different person. You do not become a different person. The silence does not lift.

But something shifts. A crack in a wall that has stood for thirty-one years.

You call again the next Sunday. And the next. And the next.

He tells you about interest rates. You tell him about Elena. He asks if you need money. You ask if he is taking his medication.

It is not poetry. It is not the conversation you imagined having. But it is real.

At sixty-eight, he dies. Not from the heart. From a fall. A staircase. A misplaced step. The things that kill you are never the things you worry about.

You fly to the funeral. You stand in the rain — it is always raining at funerals — and you watch them lower him into the ground.

You do not feel nothing.

You feel everything.

You feel the phone calls. The baking soda volcano. The articles about interest rates. The seven words he said that changed nothing and everything.

That's all I ever wanted.

You stand in the rain for a long time after everyone else has left. Sam stands beside you. Elena stands beside Sam. The three of you, holding hands, in the rain.

"Are you okay?" Sam asks.

"No," you say. "But I called him. That's what matters. I called him."

The book closed itself. The traveler did not close it. The pages folded inward, one by one, like a hand making a fist.

"I called him," the traveler said. "In my life. I called him."

The keeper said nothing.

"A year before he died. I called him. We talked about — I don't remember. Interest rates. The weather. But we talked."

"And?"

"And he said —" The traveler's voice broke. "He said he was proud of me. He had never said that before. Not once. In thirty-one years, never. And I called him, and he said it."

"And you carried that with you."

"Yes." The traveler wiped their face with the back of their hand. "But I also carried all the years I didn't call. All the Sundays I let the phone ring. All the conversations I avoided. I came to this library carrying both things. The call I made and the calls I didn't."

The keeper waited.

"Which one is real?" the traveler asked.

“Both.”

“Both?”

“The life where you called your father is real. The life where you didn’t — where you never picked up the phone, where he died without hearing your voice — that life is real too. They exist in different books. But they are both *you*.”

“And the one where I called — is that the one I’m living?”

The keeper smiled. It was the first genuine smile the traveler had seen from her.

“That,” she said, “is the question you should be asking yourself. Not the library. Not me. *Yourself*.”

The traveler looked at the book in their hands. The thin one. The one with the color of old telephone wires.

There was no margin note this time.

The margin note was the call itself.

In the margin of the sixth book, a single line, in handwriting that was not the traveler’s but the keeper’s:

The life you are living is the one you chose. The life you are living is the one you can still choose..

The Door

The last book was not a book.

The keeper led the traveler to the center of the library, where the shelves formed a circle around an empty space. In the empty space stood a single lectern. On the lectern sat a book so old its pages looked like they were made of pressed clouds.

“There are no more alternate lives,” the keeper said. “This book is not about the past.”

“Then what is it?”

“It is the book you write while you are reading it.”

The traveler did not understand. But they stepped forward anyway. They had come this far.

Open.

The first page was blank.

The traveler waited. Nothing happened. No vision. No alternate self. No smell of rain on hot asphalt.

“Is it broken?”

“Read it.”

“I can’t. There’s nothing there.”

“Read it again.”

The traveler looked. And this time, they saw:

You are standing in a library. You have read six books. Each book showed you a life you could have lived. Now you must decide: which life will you actually live?

“There’s nothing on the page.”

“Then write on it.”

“How?”

The keeper said nothing. She stood at the edge of the circle, her ink-stained hands folded, her eyes unreadable.

The traveler turned back to the blank page. And they began to speak.

“I am not the person who lost Sarah in a car accident,” they said. “And I am not the person who never boarded the train. I am the person who stood on the platform and *could* have made either choice. I am the possibility.”

The page shimmered. Words appeared:

I am the possibility.

“I am not the cartographer of things unseen,” the traveler continued. “I am not the child of a woman who speaks to trees. But I am the person who can imagine them. And imagining them changes me.”

I am the one who imagines.

“I am the person who left Sam sleeping,” the traveler said. The words came harder now. “I am the person who was afraid of the life they were living. I am the person who walked through a door instead of staying in the room they were in.”

I am the one who left.

“I am also the person who called their father.” The traveler’s voice broke. Held. “I am the person who said ‘I love you’ before it was too late. I am the person who stayed up with Elena when she was sick. I am the person who made Sam laugh, sometimes, even when I couldn’t make myself feel anything.”

I am the one who stayed.

“I am contradictions. I am the person who writes poetry and the person who stopped because no one would read it. I am the person who believes in love and the person who has built walls around themselves so high that love has to climb. I am the person who found the library and the person who is standing here, talking to a blank book, trying to understand what it means to choose.”

I am contradictions.

The traveler stopped. The book in front of them was no longer blank. It was covered in their own words. In their own handwriting. In the ink of their own voice.

“What happens now?” they asked.

The keeper stepped into the circle. She reached out and took the book from the lectern. She closed it gently, like closing a door on a room you might return to.

“Now you go home.”

“But I don’t know which life to live.”

“You do.”

“I don’t.”

The keeper held the traveler’s gaze. Her eyes, for the first time, were not tired. They were alive. They were the eyes of someone who has spent an eternity reading endings and has just found one she has never seen before.

“You came here looking for a life that would feel right,” she said. “A life without pain. Without regret. Without the emptiness. You wanted to find the version of yourself that had solved the problem of being alive.”

“Yes.”

“And what did you find?”

The traveler thought about Sarah. About the coffee mug. About the radiator in the apartment on Wilson Avenue. About the boy who carried an empty violin case. About Elena, the daughter they imagined. About the phone call. About the father who loved them in the only language he knew.

“I found that every life hurts,” the traveler said slowly. “The Boston life hurts because Sarah dies. The Chicago life hurts because Sarah never exists. The cartographer’s life hurts because time is an ocean and you drown in it. My life hurts because I am afraid.” They paused. “And the life where I said yes — where I had Elena, where I called my father — that life hurts too. But it also —”

They stopped.

“It also what?” the keeper asked.

“It also *breathes*,” the traveler said. “The life where I said yes — it breathes. It has room. It has mornings and nights and conversations that matter. It has Sam’s hand. It has Elena’s drawings. It has the phone call.”

“And the life you are actually living?”

The traveler looked at the space between the keeper’s hands. At the book that contained their own words.

“The life I am actually living,” they said, “is the one I haven’t finished writing yet.”

The keeper smiled.

“That,” she said, “is the right answer.”

The library began to change. The shelves that had stretched into infinite fog began to pull closer, compacting, folding inward like a collapsing lung. The dark wood of the lectern began to glow — not with light, but with warmth, like a stove that has been burning all winter.

“What’s happening?” the traveler asked.

“The library is closing.”

“But I haven’t read all the books.”

“Nobody does.”

“I haven’t seen the life where I ran away at nineteen. The life where I became famous. The life where I —”

“You have seen enough,” the keeper said. “More than most. The library will be here when you need it again. But you cannot stay. If you stay, you will become like me.”

“What’s wrong with being like you?”

The keeper looked at her own ink-stained hands. At the thousand years of other people’s lives written into her skin.

“I have read every book,” she said. “And I have never written one of my own.”

The traveler understood.

They looked around the collapsing library one last time. At the shelves that had held six versions of themselves. At the door that looked like the memory of a door. At the keeper, who was already beginning to fade, the way furniture fades when the light changes.

“Will I remember this?”

“Some of it. The parts you need.”

“And Sam?”

The keeper’s smile was sad, now. “Sam is waiting. They have been waiting. They will always wait. That is what Sam does.”

“Will they remember that I left?”

“Time moves differently here. When you return, it will have been an hour. Or a day. Or a year.” The keeper’s voice faded. “Sam will remember only that you walked out the door, and then walked back in.”

The traveler stood at the threshold. The book from the lectern was still in their hands, still warm, still covered in their own words.

“What’s your name?” they asked the keeper.

The keeper — the librarian of unlived lives — tilted her head. Her ink-stained fingers brushed her own cheek.

“I was you,” she said. “A long time ago. I came here and I never left. I read every book. I became the keeper. And now you are standing where I stood, and you are choosing differently.”

“How do you know?”

“Because if you were going to stay,” the keeper said, “you would not have asked my name.”

The traveler looked at the door. The real door. The one that led back to the world with doors and windows and other people.

“What happens to you?” they asked.

“The library needs a keeper.”

“Will you be free?”

The keeper laughed. It was the first time the traveler had heard her laugh. It sounded like the first rain after a drought.

“I have been free for a thousand years,” she said. “I just didn’t know it.”

The traveler stepped through the door.

The morning light was silver and cold. The apartment was exactly as they had left it: the unmade bed, the half-empty coffee cup, the cat sleeping on the windowsill.

Sam was in the kitchen. Their back was to the door. They were making tea — the same way they had made tea every morning for six years. The kettle whistled. The spoon clinked against the ceramic.

The traveler stood in the doorway and watched.

“Sam.”

Sam turned. Their face was neutral. Tired. “You were gone a while.”

“Was I?”

“An hour. Maybe two. I woke up and you weren’t here.”

The traveler looked down at their hands. Empty now. The book was gone. But they could still feel the weight of it. The weight of their own words.

"I went to the library," they said.

"The one at the end of the street?"

"No. A different one."

Sam studied them. The way Sam does — patient, careful, reading the spaces between words.

"Did you find what you were looking for?"

The traveler thought about it. About the keeper. About the six books. About the blank page that had filled itself with everything they were too afraid to say.

"I found out that every life hurts," they said. "And every life also breathes." They walked into the kitchen. "I also found out that I want to say yes."

"Yes to what?"

"To Elena. To calling my father. To writing poetry even if no one reads it." They took Sam's hand. "To this."

"This isn't a perfect life," Sam said.

"I know."

"It's not the one where everything works out."

"I know."

"It's just —"

Sam stopped. They were crying. Not noisily. Just two tears, falling without permission.

"It's just *ours*," Sam said.

The traveler pulled them close. The morning light fell through the kitchen window. The cat stretched. The kettle cooled.

"It's just ours," the traveler said. "And that is enough."

The library is still there. Somewhere. Between one thought and the next. In the space where a door might be that looks like the memory of a door.

The keeper is still there. Reading. Waiting.

But the traveler does not come back.

Not because they don't need to.

Because they have finally understood: the library was never about finding the right life.

It was about learning to live the one they already had.

In the margin of the seventh book, in ink that had always been there, a single line in handwriting that was both the traveler's and the keeper's:

I did not know that home was not a place. That it was the willingness to stay..
